

Creative Skill Development Plan

CIM301.1 Project 1

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Table Of Contents

Deliverables:	1
Template Information and Use.....	2
1.0 - Industry Skills Research	2
2.0 - Industry Skills Gap Analysis (SWOT Analysis)	2
3.0 - Project Portfolio Vision	2
4.0 - Project Plan	3
4.1 - Deliberate Practice Plan.....	3
4.2 - GANTT Chart.....	3
4.3 - List of Potential Learning Materials (readings, tutorials, videos, lessons).....	3
4.4 - Proof of Concept Demonstration Media Asset(s).....	3
5.0 - Slide Deck	4
6.0 - Video Presentation	4
7.0 - Project Checklist	4
Additional Links (if necessary).....	4
8.0 - Reference List	5
9.0 - AI Use Declaration	5

Deliverables:

1. Project Slide Deck titled: CIM301.1 Creative Skill Development Plan, including:

- Industry Skills Gap analysis
- Individual goal-setting exercises
- Supporting materials

2. A 5-10 minute video recording of your slide deck presentation submitted as a .MOV or .MP4

1.0 - Industry Skills Research

The current audio industry requires the basic understanding of audio fundamentals. These include signal flow, troubleshooting skills, audio physics, how audio reacts. As Avril Martinez says in Tucker's book *Finding Your Career in the Modern Audio Industry* "There's so much crossover in audio skills as long as you have that strong foundation of what audio is, how it works, and some basic physics" (2022, p. 127).

Proficiency with a variety of industry tools such as DAWs like Pro Tools, Reaper, Ableton Live and a quick workflow are essentials for audio practitioners looking to find success in the audio industry. These tools are industry standard in many professional audio workplaces and having a quick workflow enables you to meet tight deadlines, while also being able to be flexible in the face of creative changes.

Alongside the technical skills, being proficient in multiple audio specific skills such as music and audio production, mixing, post production, interactive media (game audio), audiovisual industry, and live sound, can significantly increase one's employability and versatility in the audio industry. While it is highly favoured to specialise in one particular area of the field, it is also advantageous and beneficial to be equipped with a vast skill set. As this industry evolves over-time, it is becoming increasingly important to have multiple skills under your belt as many audio practitioners are responsible for multiple roles within a project.

For those pursuing a career in game and interactive media audio, a foundational understanding of programming is highly favoured, although not essential. A skill that seems to be becoming increasingly more invaluable in this industry is experience with audio to game middleware software, such as Wwise and FMOD. Game sound designers may also be required to have compositional knowledge as well, in the event that they are required to compose musical pieces for the game project. It also goes without saying that a strong foundation and understanding of sound design is also a must for any aspiring sound designer. This is especially true for roles in interactive media where layering and creating unique sounds is sought after to help create a more immersive experience for the consumer.

In addition to the audio specific skills and the technical skills, soft skills such as good communication are a crucial component in the audio industry. Good communication skills are valuable when speaking to potential and existing clients, project directors and developers, while possessing collaborative skills such as teamwork is a must-have, as audio practitioners are working with other specialists for the majority. Networking is a staple skill in any creative industry, but especially in the audio industry, as it's a key component in the process of finding work. While creative problem solving and critical thinking are a must in this industry, a skill that is often overlooked is having a sound understanding of business acumen, as this can give you a competitive edge in the industry with knowledge of contracts, budgeting and client management. Lastly, having the self-motivation, the drive and a curious mindset will get you far in the industry.

2.0 - Industry Skills Gap Analysis (SWOT Analysis)

STRENGTHS	WEAKNESSES
→ Hard Skills ◆ Proficient in Ableton ◆ Understand basic audio fundamentals	→ Hard Skills ◆ Pro Tools (beginner level) ◆ Reaper (no experience) ◆ Minimal layering skills

◆ Basic signal flow ◆ Good general mixing & effects skill ◆ Good Dialogue editing skills ◆ Sound library management → Soft Skills ◆ Good communication skills ◆ Teamwork & collaboration skills ◆ Curious-minded ◆ Adaptable & flexible ◆ Customer service mindset ◆ Problem-solving attitude ◆ Attention to detail mindset	◆ No experience coding/programming ◆ Slow workflow ◆ Minimal sound design & mastering knowledge ◆ Basic knowledge of synthesis ◆ Basic hardware/analog knowledge → Soft Skills ◆ No networking skills ◆ Business acumen ◆ Procrastination/task paralysis ◆ Very limited work experience ◆ Poor time management skills ◆ Not very self-driven
OPPORTUNITIES	THREATS
→ Emerging Trends & Experience ◆ Podcasting audio work ◆ Consulting & education ◆ Game engine online training ◆ VR/AR spatial audio ◆ AI advancements in audio and generate ideas ◆ Capstone projects → Industry Demands ◆ Dolby Atmos routing & experience ◆ Live sound and location for sound ◆ Portfolio ◆ Soft skill development	→ Personal Barriers ◆ No dedicated studio with acoustic treatment ◆ Social media marketing ◆ Slim opportunities in Perth ◆ Low income ◆ My perfectionism complex → Industry/Workplace Threats ◆ Less demand for sound engineers in studios ◆ AI taking opportunities ◆ Devaluing collaboration within the industry ◆ Oversaturation of the job market ◆ Expensive software

Started with Ableton and have a very good grasp on it's workflow but in audio Pro Tools is considered the industry standard, especially in film. I have a basic understanding of Pro Tools from my studies at SAE but it could definitely be a lot better if I remembered a lot of the shortcuts. While Reaper is not an industry standard yet, it is especially good for game audio projects which is the main area I would like to get into, however I have no experience in Reaper. I also need to have a faster workflow as my slow workflow and inability to move on from a certain task can inhibit my creative bandwidth.

I did consider myself to have a good understanding of audio fundamentals and basic understanding of signal flow though they could be better. My mixing, dialogue editing and understanding of effects is also intermediate and I am confident in my abilities. However even after so many years of attempting sound design and synthesis I find it to be still difficult. I understand that a lot of sound design for video games is to do with layering (insert game audio source of layering) but it is also something I am still fairly new to.

Having a basic understanding of programming and coding in the game industry is also beneficial according to Tucker's book *Finding Your Career in the Modern Audio Industry* (p. 336) as he states that on a big game project they will have an audio programmer to just program the audio but in some smaller cases you might be the only audio person on the team therefore having knowledge to program the audio is a big plus.

I do think I have very good soft skill strengths with communication, teamwork and adaptability skills

being my strongest. I also think having attention to detail and customer service work ethic is great as you'll win over clients that way. However I do lack some time management skills, procrastination and have very poor networking skills. These are skills I really want to develop but they aren't exactly skills I'd want to do a project on.

Some opportunities that I've listed consist of both emerging trends and industry demands. With the rise of podcasts there's bound to be a lot more audio work. To figure out the necessary skills to contribute to these podcasts would go a long way. One of my lecturers stated that studios and pretty much everywhere are in need of practitioners with an understanding of dolby atmos and spatial audio routing, this is a great opportunity to upskill as it's an industry demand.

Advancements in AI have helped in everyday life in nearly every field. Understanding how to leverage AI to help either generate ideas/speed up workflow or even how to use some of the new AI technology coming out would help heaps.

As stated previously about not having any experience in the programming side of game audio and VR/AR spatial audio, there is a wealth of knowledge of programming some of these game engines on YouTube but also the game engine companies themselves like Unreal and Unity.

Threats to me that would pose a challenge to me entering the industry would be threats such as the slow decline of engineers in conventional studios, especially in Perth where there is already not a lot of jobs going compared to other cities around the globe. And although I said the emergence of AI is a good thing for the industry there is the collective fear that it could take away more opportunities and could devalue collaboration in the industry due to the technology being able to complete all these different audio tasks essentially making whoever has the budget for these tools a one stop hyper individual practitioner.

I also have a low income atm and can't afford some of the software that would help my workflow as a lot of the gear and software is really expensive. There are workarounds but unfortunately these could be too time consuming and might inhibit me rather than keep at the same level as others who have the software.

Also in a world where to be a successful freelancer you have to have business skills along with good social media promoting skills, both of which I lack.

2.1 - Project Brainstorm

Re-designing short film scenes in Pro Tools each week

Creating a synth patch every day

Re-designing the SFX for 5 different genre game scenes using Reaper every week.

Writing a track every week to speed up workflow (1 hour a day doing 3 aspects of the songwriting process)

Uncovering what is needed for successful podcast audio and recording a short podcast every week successfully

4.0 - Project Plan

4.1 - Project Portfolio Vision

Specific

The goal is to sound re-design a 45 second- 1 minute clip from 2 different games using Ableton & Reaper. Each of the game scenes will be a different genre and both scenes will come together to form a short demo reel. Each clip will have a video walkthrough of the process to accompany the showreel, as employers look at evidence detailing the process. Not only will I have a showreel for my portfolio/to give to employers, it will get me familiar with Reaper and how it works with game audio/sound design as I will complete each clip in Ableton initially in the first week before repeating the process in Reaper the following week.

Measurable

Setting up an asset list in google sheets for each scene will be essential to complete the project in a timely manner. These asset lists will require that I identify any existing sounds in my library that might fit the scene, any sounds I can source that might fit the scene, and any sounds that may need to be recorded. Pre-selecting the game scenes and allocating them to a block of 2 weeks will also be part of the pre-planning process, along with any templates that may need to be created to help with workflow. Recording and synthesising any of the assets will be conducted first over at least 2 days, with the arranging, layering and mixing being conducted the following days.

Achievable

In terms of scope, I believe 2 well polished clips are achievable for me. I have the tools available at home to complete the task, as well as online tutorials on YouTube.

Relatable

The project is designed to improve my basic layering and sound design skills, however, it is also improving 3 skills that were identified as a weakness in my SWOT analysis; Reaper proficiency, workflow speed, and my time management skills. This project will provide me with a piece of work to include in my portfolio and present future employers, while also setting me up for any future sound design work in game audio or film.

Time-bound

Setting up a GANTT chart of how the project is to unfold week to week should give me a solid framework and timeline to work with. The pre-planning stage is crucial for this to work however, as I don't want it to eat into the allocated time I have for each scene. The project has a length of 5 weeks before it's due; I hope to have it completed by the end of the 4th week. I designed it this way so then if any extra time is needed, I have 1 extra week to complete the project. This was the main reason I only opted to do 2 clips instead of 4-5.

Evaluated

At the end of each cluster of sessions (recording cluster, mixing cluster) I will evaluate the completed work to see if any more work needs to be carried over to the following sessions. During this time I will do a 10 minute reflective entry. Feedback from my mentor will also be provided each week.

Revised

The project will be revised and readjusted upon reflection and/or if feedback from mentors deems that adjustment is needed to meet the unit's learning outcomes. This will usually happen every Monday.

4.2 - Deliberate Practice Plan

Challenge

Both clips will be a different genre therefore requiring a different approach. For example, if one is a first person shooter and the other is a fantasy game, they will have different sound and asset requirements. The same fundamentals are still in play but the approach is different.

Focus

As mentioned before, each session will be aimed at a different element of sound design of that clip such as recording or synthesising the sounds, the layering and arrangement of the sounds, and the creative mixing of each element. Another example, using sound design to create an explosion/impact would require different processing than recording/sourcing and sculpting a character's foley. By having these dedicated sessions to each element, it ensures that I'm developing these sub skills related to sound design (layering, signal processing etc) equally and effectively. It will also be developing my understanding of Reaper at the same time. Learning and applying the DAW's shortcuts will be advantageous.

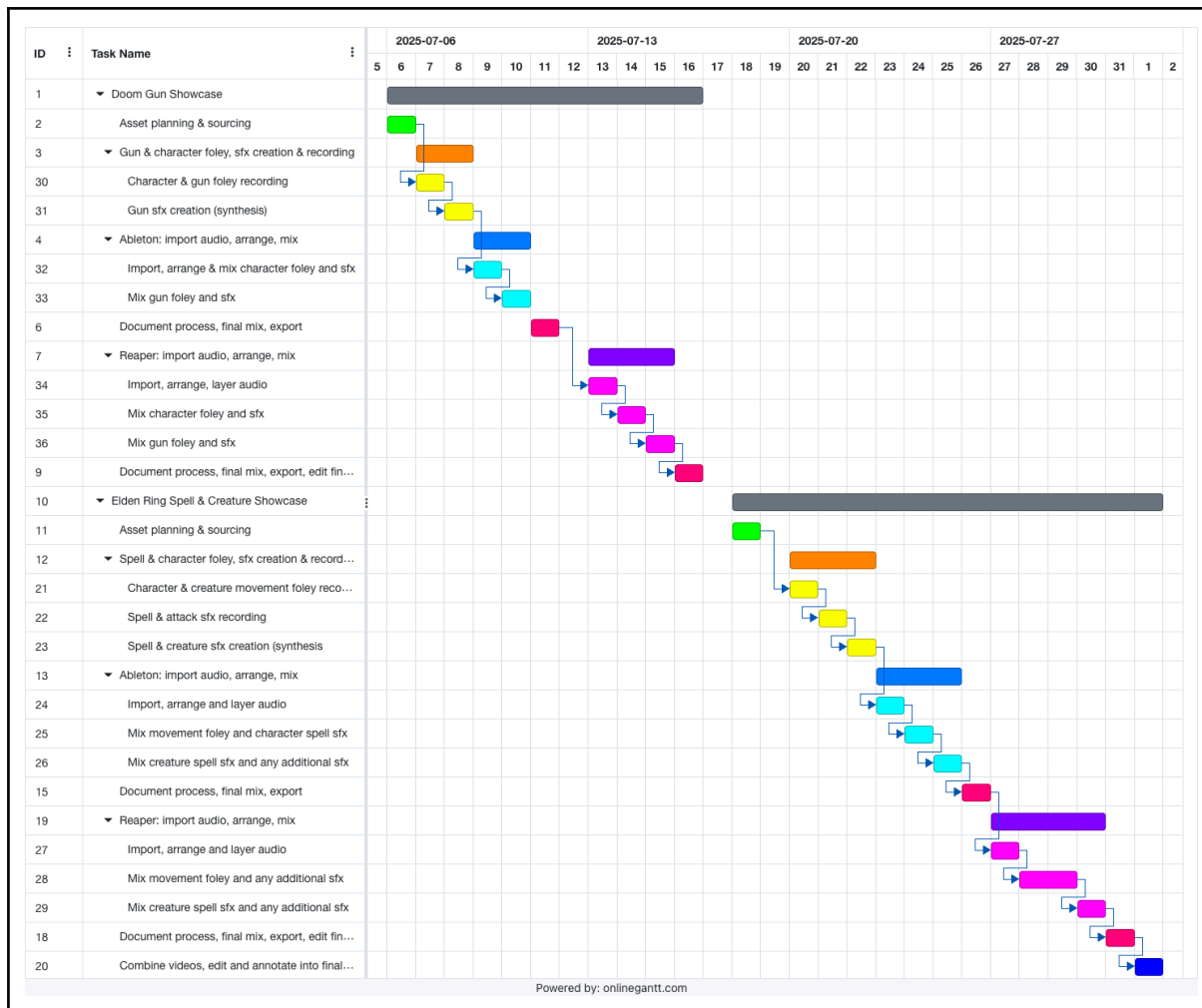
Repetition

Although each clip and session is different, each week follows the same framework and schedule as the previous. This repeated workflow will not only help the speed of my own workflow but the similar practices will help with developing the skills for the following session. These sessions will also be conducted in the morning before attempting any personal work to ensure that a session does not get missed.

Feedback

After each cluster of sessions I will reflect on my practice to cite any shortcomings or areas of improvements that can be rectified in the following sessions. At the end of each week the areas that need improvement will be used as a main focus point for the following week's process. These focus points will also be brought to my mentor on Monday's class for assistance. After completing both clips I should have enough spare time to fix up any issues I had with any of the clips in the previous weeks.

4.3 - GANTT Chart



4.4 - List of Potential Learning Materials (readings, tutorials, videos, lessons)

Charron, P. (2024, September 7). *How to make a Demo Reel in Sound Design*. Silverplatter Audio. <https://silverplatteraudio.com/blogs/blog/how-to-make-a-demo-reel-in-sound-design>

A step by step guide to creating a demo reel for sound design. It covers topics such as selecting the correct videos, sourcing sounds, and whether to or not include music.

Marks, A. (2017). Aaron Marks' Complete Guide to Game Audio. In A K Peters/CRC Press eBooks. Informa. <https://doi.org/10.1201/9781315758442>

Aaron covers a handle full of topics related to sound design. In particular chapters 2 (skillset & tools), 9 (creating sound effects for games), 10 (field recording for games), and 12 (blending the total soundscape) are of use to me.

Miraglia, D., & Rosenbaum, S. (2023, June 30). *Reaper DAW 101: The Official Beginner's Guide To Using Reaper*. Unison. <https://unison.audio/reaper-daw/>

This page covers the very basics of using Reaper such as, initial setup, recording and editing within the DAW, and unlocking less known features.

Pod Peak. (2021, November 27). *100 Reaper Tips and Shortcuts (for Beginners)*. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3AToV1uoqqY>

A video that includes a great amount of shortcuts and advice regarding using Reaper. This is a video I will need to take notes while viewing.

Riot Games. (2018). So You Wanna Make Games?? | Episode 8: Sound Design. In *YouTube*. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KcorlwJscFA>

A video quickly covering sound design in a variety of different genre games.

Riviere, A. (2023). *Game Audio Mixing*. Focal Press. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003351146>

Chapters 3 (game audio mixing basics), 6 (frequency spectrum), 7 (dynamics), and 9 (space) cover topics that could help my final mix of the scenes.

Sinclair, J.-L. (2020). *Principles of Game Audio and Sound Design*. Focal Press.

<https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315184432>

The only chapter that relates to my project is chapter 5 (sound design-the art of effectively communicating with sound).

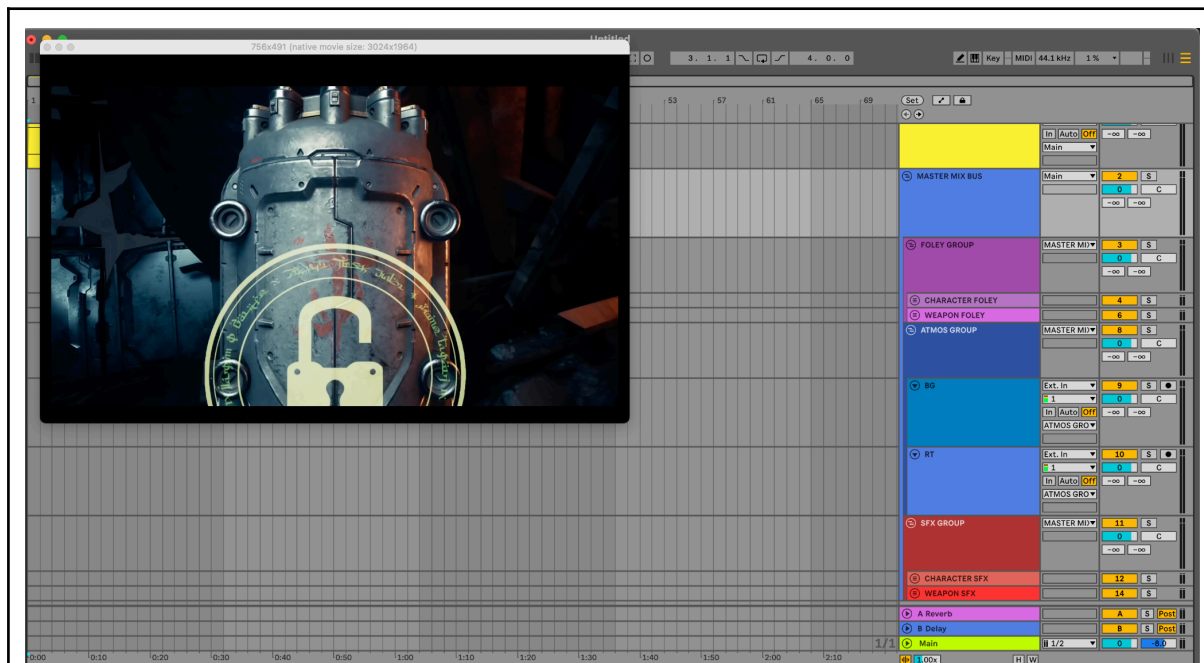
Trainor-Fogleman, E. (n.d.). *20 sound design tips and tricks to improve the quality of your next project* | *Evercast Blog*. *Www.evercast.us*. <https://www.evercast.us/blog/sound-design-tips>

A blog post detailing 20 tips to improve sound design including, layering, the addition of noise, and plugin order.

Zizza, K. (2023). *Game Audio Fundamentals*. Focal Press. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003218821>

This book includes a lot of useful information in every chapter. It mainly focuses on theory, developing a strong sound design foundation, and practical settings.

4.5 - Proof of Concept Demonstration Media Asset(s)



I've created a quick draft template for Ableton to begin work on the project. Each element of the clip has been sorted into the correlated groups for later processing. As this is a rough draft, I will need to determine what's best to include in my final template for this project.

5.0 - Slide Deck

Your slide deck can be used in your video presentation as you discuss the above points in depth. Your information provided above should be used to discuss your project in terms of the following points:

- *The overall vision of the project*
- *Why it's important to develop this skill*
- *What you will be submitting*
- *How you will be undertaking the process of learning*
- *When you will be finishing it by*

Link:	 Slide Deck
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6.0 - Video Presentation

Link:	 Video Presentation .webm
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7.0 - Project Checklist

****IMPORTANT:** *Ensure you have made all links available to download to “Anyone with the link”. If you do not, your facilitator may be unable to access your project files.*

Checklist (E.g. Yes or No)	
Have you completed all sections of this project template?	☒
Have you included at least one (1) APA7 reference in your Industry Skills Analysis?	☒
Set your video share link to “Anyone with the link” and paste the link above.	☒
Have you included your reference list below?	☒
Have you signed the AI Use Declaration below?	☒
Have you deleted all of the italicised text/prompts throughout this document?	☒

8.0 - Reference List

Tucker, A. (2022). *Finding Your Career in the Modern Audio Industry*. Focal Press.

<https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003050346>

Bandai Namco, & FromSoftware. (2025). *Review: "Nightreign" is a mini supercharged "Elden Ring" for co-op fanatics* [Image].

<https://www.npr.org/2025/05/28/nx-s1-5413534/elden-ring-nightreign-game-review>

Cockos. (2024). *Reaper* [Image]. <https://www.kvraudio.com/product/reaper-by-cockos>

Neves, H. (2024). *Cockos REAPER 7.22: Your Powerful and Flexible Digital Audio Workstation - Free Download Now!* [Image].

<https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/cockos-reaper-722-your-powerful-flexible-digital-audio-heitor-neves-aggjf/>

Xbox Game Studios. (2024). *Doom: The Dark Ages gameplay reportedly shown at QuakeCon, revealing a revamped glory kill system and a mech with a cannon* [Image].

<https://www.gamesradar.com/games/fps/doom-the-dark-ages-gameplay-reportedly-shown-at-quakecon-revealing-a-revamped-glory-kill-system-and-a-mech-with-a-cannon/>

9.0 - AI Use Declaration

I hereby confirm that have not used generative AI in the completion of this project.

If generative AI was used, complete the following (otherwise remove this and the text below)

I acknowledge the use of [AI tool name] (AI tool link) to generate...

Prompt: Examples of prompts used include...

Use: I used the output to...